Myanmar's legislature, the Hluttaw, was involved in accommodating these transitional conflicts and its effectiveness and assertiveness were not always the same.[1] For instance, its involvement in the ethnic conflict and the peace negotiations was more ceremonial than crucial (Ei Ei Toe Lwin 2013). Next, the Hluttaw was mostly silent on the communal violence in Rakhine State (Ei Ei Toe Lwin 2014a). While it was less responsive to violent clashes like the Letpadaung copper mine conflict, the legislature was quick to flex its muscles against the CTU when the latter ruled against the legislature (Nardi 2012). Moreover, while the government showed signs of compromise with the students on the amendments to the national education bill, the Hluttaw was firm in its process, and rejected the deadline set by the student movement to amend the law (Htoo Thant and Mratt Kyaw Thu 2015). In land-grabbing disputes, the legislature was proactive and had substantial achievements (Thiri Min Tun 2012).

Each of the conflicts was different in nature and therefore required a different legislative response. Some were long-standing conflicts such as the peace process, while some were new, as in the case of communal violence. Some were fast moving as in the case of Letpadaung copper mine conflict, while some encountered many bureaucratic hurdles as in the case of land-grabbing conflicts. Therefore, the legislature's response and its influence were understandably different in each case.

Contributing to a broader literature with empirical evidence from Myanmar, this chapter attempts to understand the role of the legislature in conflict resolution by looking at the Hluttaw's response to major issues and conflicts during its first term (2011–16). In order to better capture its characteristics, it looks at three different types of conflict mentioned above that can be regarded as important challenges in Myanmar's nascent transition. They are: (i) resource-based disputes; (ii) borderland conflicts and peace negotiations; and (iii) communal violence.

In each case study, I look at the assertiveness and effectiveness of the legislature and the type of legislative tools applied. In particular, I am interested in the use of conventional legislative tools such as consultation and dialogue among lawmakers and with stakeholders, and during legislative debates. The main goal of my chapter is neither to discuss legislative politics (including factional politics and clientelism) nor to compare specific legislative responses to these conflicts, but rather to extract empirical data from them in order to better understand the Hluttaw's institutional characteristics.